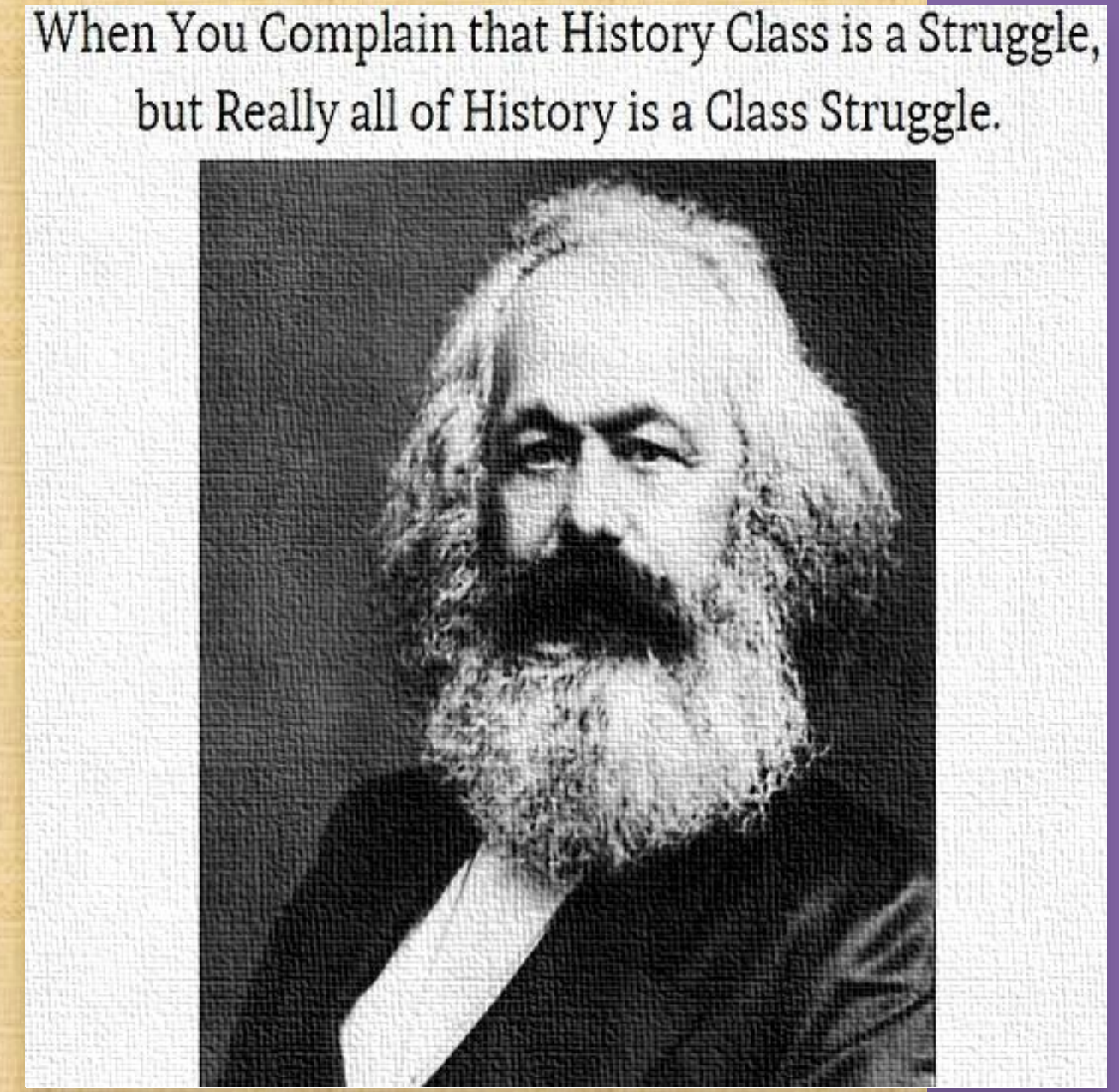
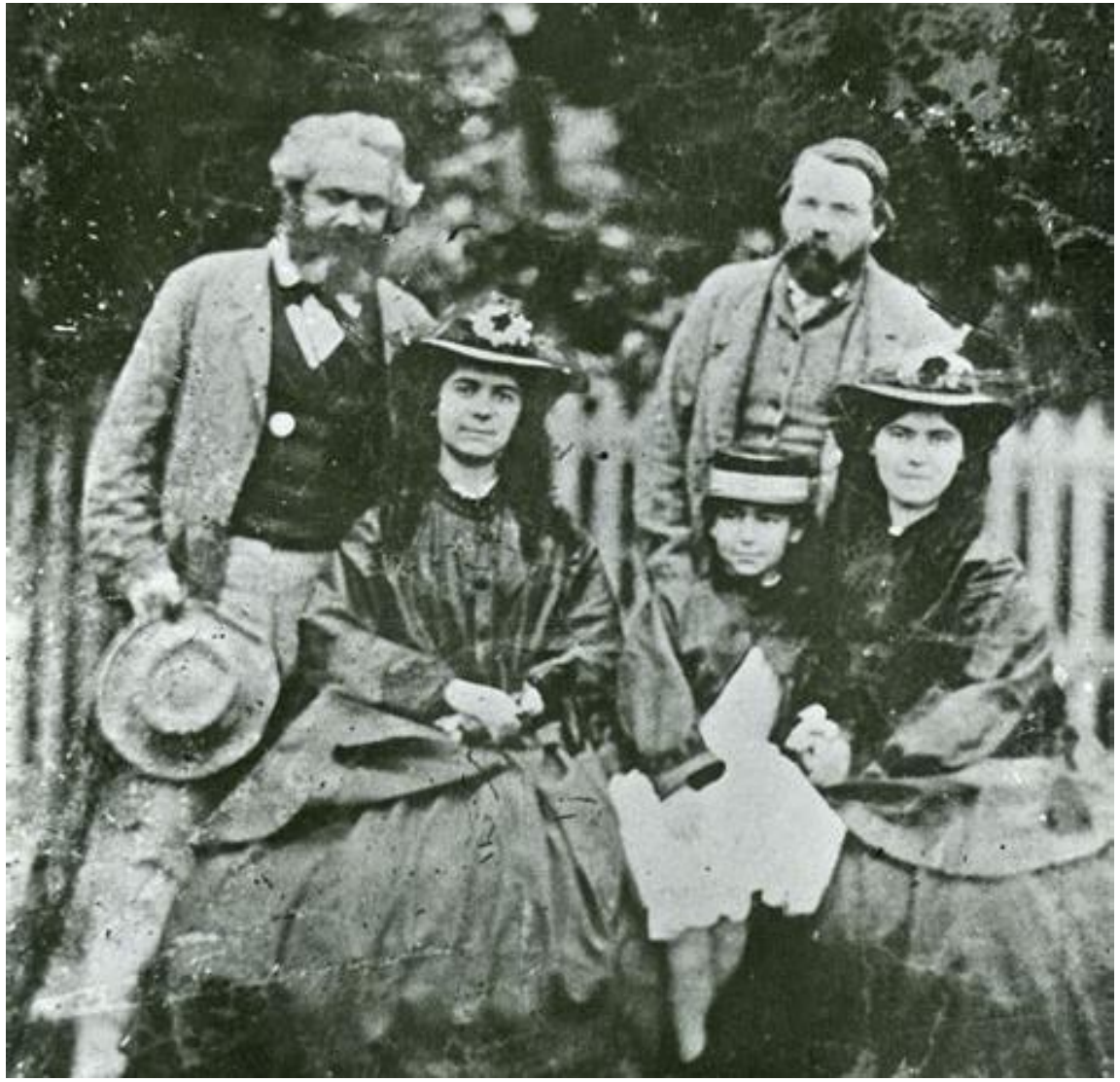
- Aniket Alam
- Introduction to History HS3.201
- Monsoon 2026

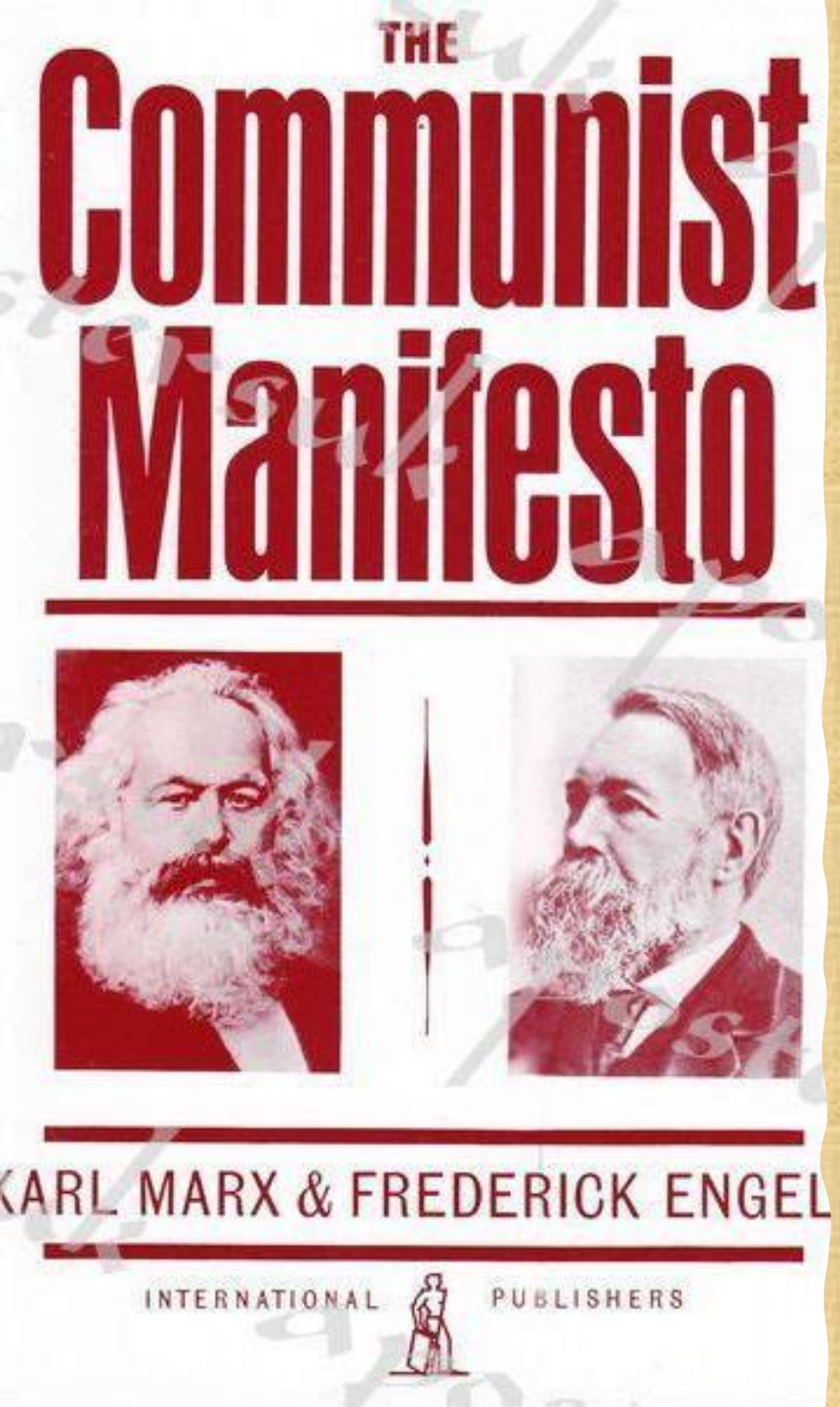
Marxist History



Who was Karl Marx

- German Jewish family; converted
- Studied Philosophy; influenced by Hegel
  - Neo Hegelian
  - **Dialectics** as a method to study society
  - **Materialism** as starting point
- Radical Ideas about the world and how to change it
  - Political Activist; Exile in London where he wrote most of his works
  - Working Mens International Association





Why Did Marx Study History?

- Marx Was Interested In Knowing
  1. What Is Wrong With The World; And
  2. How To Change It (For The Better)
- How do we understand historical change?
  - Why do societies change
  - How do societies work
- We need a scientific basis for understanding and explanation

Starting Off…

- Facts, Objectivity, Evidence All Essential
- Humanist Stand-point Accepted
- But These Are Insufficient In Themselves!
- What Is The Theory Of Change
  - Dialectics
- How To Make It Scientific
  - Materialism

Materialism

MATTER PRIMARY, IDEA SECONDARY

- Understanding the material world in which human beings live has to take precedence over understanding the intentions or ideas which activate human actions

- Ideas cannot exist without matter
- Matter can exist without ideas

- God or Ideas do not create World and Man
- Man or Actions create God and World

Materialism

According to the materialist conception, the determining factor in history is, in the final instance, the production and reproduction of immediate life. This, again, is of a twofold character: on the one side, the production of the means of existence, of food, clothing, and shelter and the tools necessary for that production; on the other side, the production of human beings themselves, the propagation of the species. The social organisation under which the people of a particular historical epoch and a particular country live is determined by both kinds of production: by the stage of the development of labour on the one hand and of the family on the other.

~Fredrick Engels~

Dialectics

- Against Dualism
  - Mind and Matter are not two different states of being but different expressions of the same being
- Theory of Contradiction
  - Thesis -> Anti-Thesis -> Synthesis (thesis)
  - Idea of Negation
  - Evolutionary
- Cannot know self without the other

Three Laws of Dialectics

1. The unity and conflict of opposites
   - Contradictions work by conflict and unity

2. The passage of quantitative change to qualitative changes
   - A thing is more than the sum of its parts
   - A sufficiently large change in quantity changes the nature of the thing

3. The negation of the negation
   - Unity and conflict of opposites negates the previous stages
   - Builds higher stage; which in turn is negated by same process

Dialectical Materialism

- Dialectics starts with Matter (inert) in Motion (opposite of inert)
- Matter <-> Motion <-> Higher Stage of Matter <->
  - Brain <-> Mind <-> External World <-> Ideas
- Lower stage exists within the higher stage
- Unified all existence from sub-atomic elements to philosophy
- Theory of History : Historical Materialism
  - Explained how one state of society evolves (changes) into the other

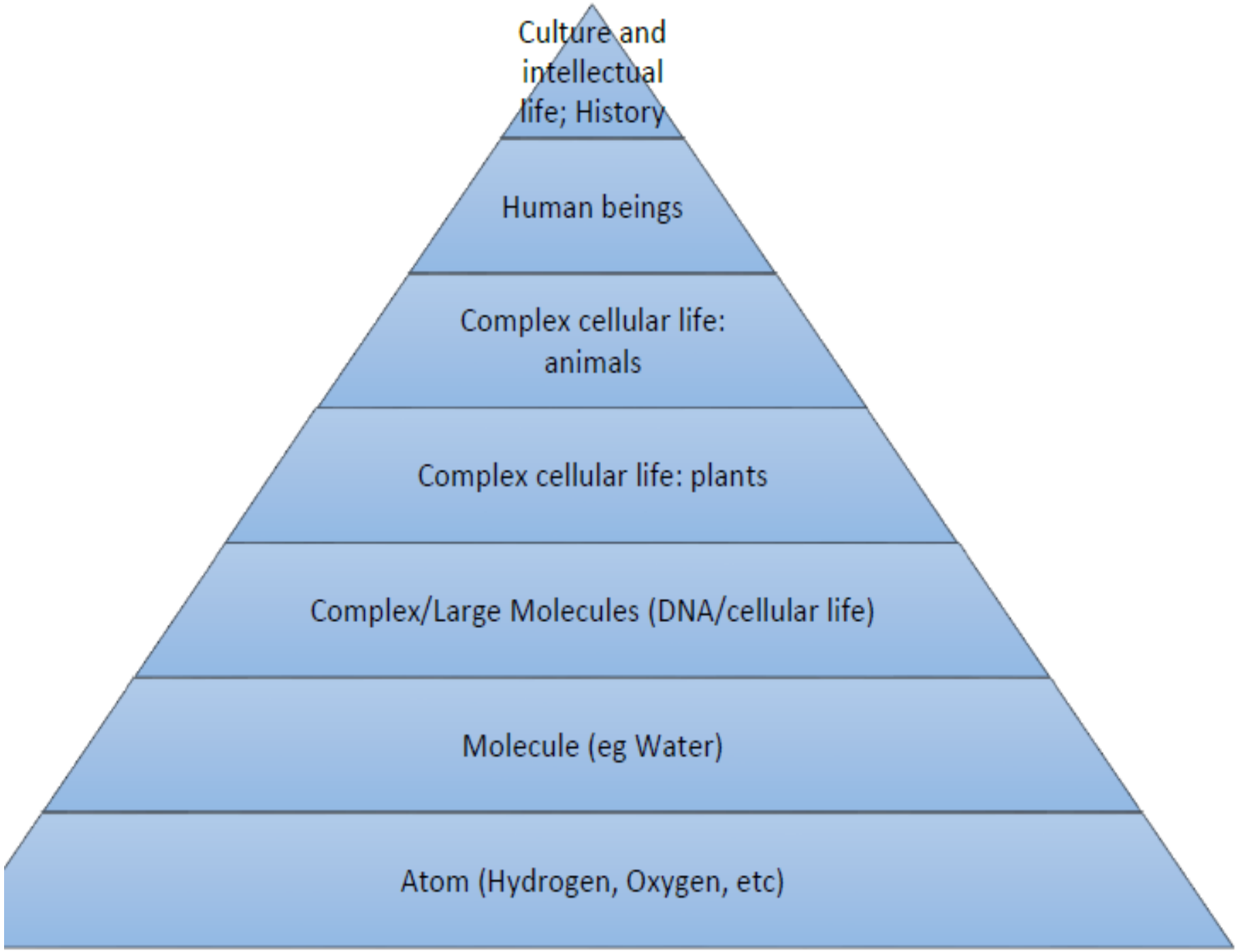
Historical - Materialism

- No conceptual break between natural world and the human world
  - Bound together in a common explanatory grid
- History is merely a particular form of “Matter in Motion”

- Historian has to:
  1. Identify the “Material Basis” of social formation
  2. Identify the “Dialectical Contradictions” in social formation

- Work out stages through which human society evolved from origin till present
  - Each Stage is the actualisation of a dialectical contradiction
  - Each Stage changes after it reaches its full potential

A Conceptual Pyramid to Explain Dialectics



Labour

- Labour makes us Human
  - Labour distinguishes Humans from Nature
- Labour creates all value (Labour Theory of Value)

  "the hand is not only the organ of labour, it is also the product of labour."
- Labour is conscious action
  - Purpose
  - Plan
  - Learning from Failure
- Human condition is the result of the dialectical relation between labour and external world



Role of Labour in History

- Labour at the root of Ape becoming Man
  - Labour leads to surplus
  - Surplus leads to social stratification
  - Social Stratification is also division of labour
- First social division of labour was sexual
  - Between man and woman, creating the family
- Form of Labour, and…
- …Extraction of Value Created by Labour…
- …Defines all different forms of society



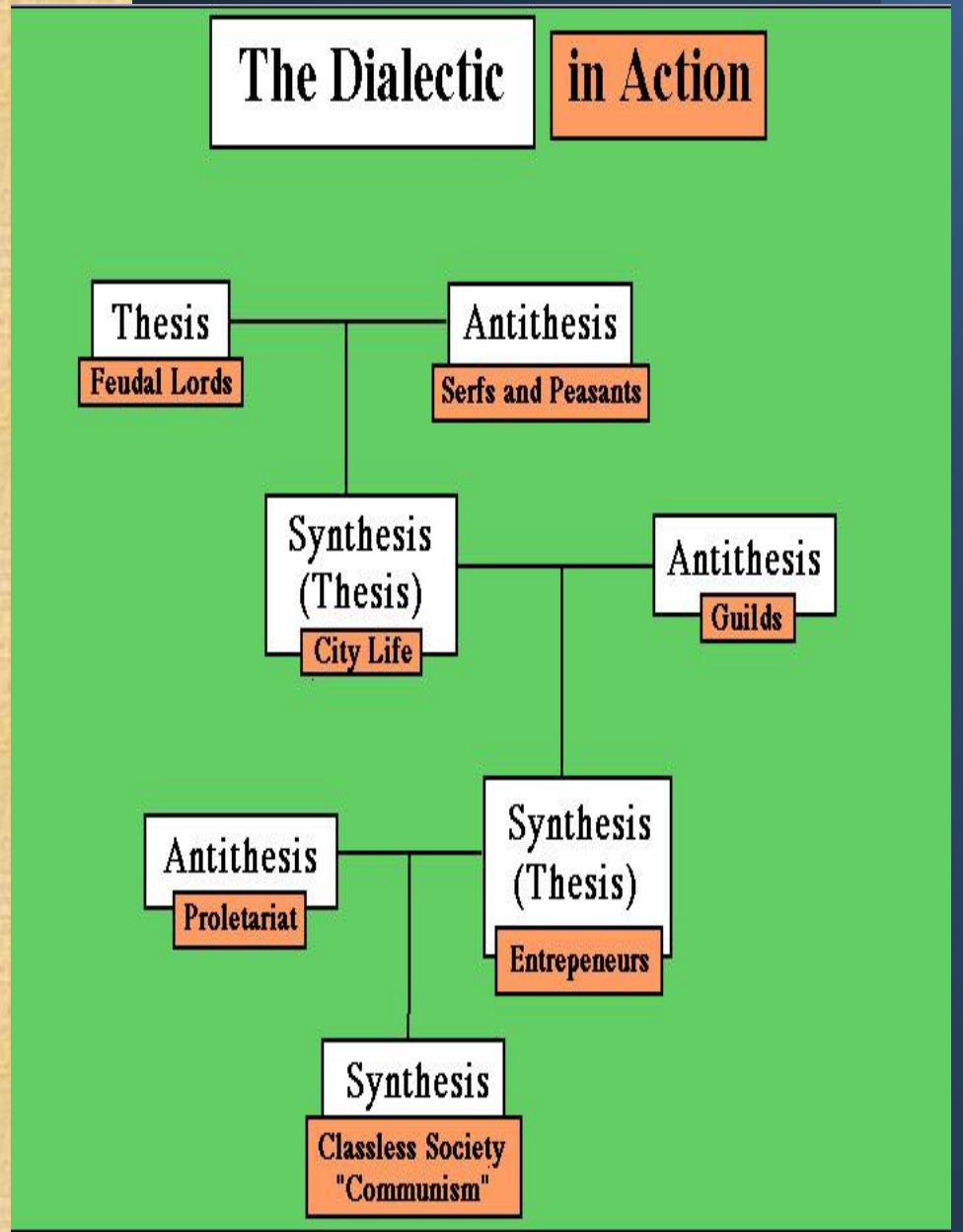
Surplus



- Surplus is accumulated labour
  - Dead Labour
- Labour creates Humans; Surplus creates civilisation
- Turns dialectics from relation between
  - Man and Nature to Man and Man
- Divisions within society
  - Who has Dead Labour (Surplus) and who has Living Labour

Class Struggle

- Motor of History: Struggle between dead labour and living labour
  - Means of Production and Relations of Production
- This Struggle defines form of society
  - **Primitive**, **Slave**, **Feudal**, **Capitalism**
  - **Asiatic**
- Dialectics of history creates new society within old society
  - Move to higher level of relation between dead and living labour or collapse

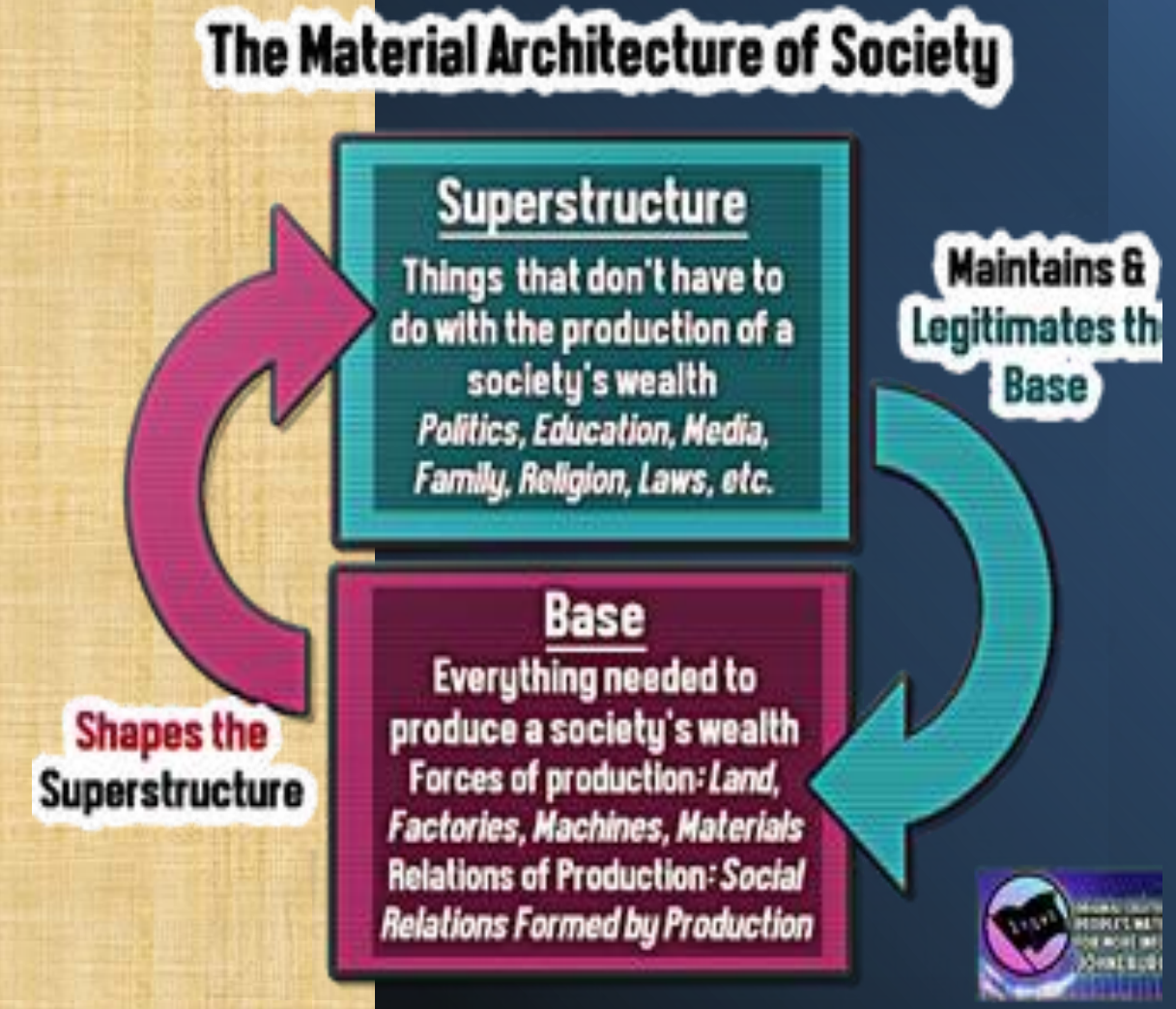


Base Superstructure

- Means of Production and Forces of Production form base of society

- Superstructure is what keeps the base stable and running
- Economy as base
- Politics, Laws, Culture as superstructure

- In Dialectics can these be so fixed?



Marxist Historiography
Colonialism

- Colonialism As Part Of Capitalism
  - Transfer Of Resources From Periphery To Metropolis
- Coloniser And Colonised: Class Divides Both
- Whom Does Colonialism Exploit
  - Working Class And Peasantry Of Coloniser Country
  - Peasantry, Workers, Also Some Landlords And Merchants Of Colonised
- Whom Does Colonialism Benefit
  - Ruling Classes Of Coloniser
  - Ruling Classes Of Colonised
- Colonialism Is A System; Not About Individuals
- Colonial Relations Can Continue Even After Political Independence

Marxist Historiography
Indian Freedom Struggle

- It Was Not Merely Britain Exploiting India
- Who Benefited
  - New Landlords
  - Mercantile And Trading Communities
  - New Urban Professionals
- Who Were Dispossessed And Exploited
  - Peasants, Tribals
  - Old Landed Class; Kings And Zamindars
- Common Interests Among Some Indian And British Social Classes
  - Both Ruling And Exploited
- What Does "Freedom" from British Rule Imply?
  - For Whom?
  - Who Benefits?

Marxist Historiography
Mughal India and its Decline

- Why Did Mughal Empire Suddenly Become So Strong Under Akbar?
- Why Did It Decline Under/After Aurangzeb?
- Personality? Religious Policy? Luck?

- **Class Relations**
  - How Was Rural Class Relations Organised
  - How Was State Nobility Organised
  - Structural Problems

- Agrarian Structure, Social Relations Of Production, Political Management Of Social Classes… These Determine Whether An Empire Grows Or Declines

Three Advances



- One: does not ask us to make any *a priori* assumptions of first cause of History
- Two: provides us with a theory to understand causation in history without necessarily reducing it to determinism
- Three: Enables us to link understanding with explanation.
  - The move from knowledge to practice is contained within the same theory; that it allows for theory to become practice.

Three Problems



- Determinism
  - Laws of History
  - The relation between Structure and Agency
- Hierarchy of Causation
  - Economic Determinism
  - Teleology
- Closed Explanatory System
  - Historical Inevitability
  - History begins and ends at definite points

